

North Korea



Separated from the democratic South by the world's most heavily defended border, the Stalinist North Korean state has been isolated from the outside world since 1948.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly mountainous, with fertile plains in the southwest.



CLIMATE

Continental. Warm summers and cold winters, especially in the north, where snow is common.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Life is heavily regulated. Cult of personality is more powerful than the state-controlled religions, which include Korea's own Chondogyo. Women are expected to work and to run the home. Children are looked after in state-run crèches. The Korean Worker's Party is the sole party. Its elite have a privileged lifestyle. Globally condemned for its nuclear weapons development, its grip on power perpetuates its pariah status.



INSIGHT: Only the political elite are allowed phones and private cars



THE ECONOMY

Minerals are only resource. Vital aid streams lost with global collapse of communism after 1989. Decades of economic mismanagement have led to chronic food shortages. Lack of fuel. Disproportionate defense budget.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic People's Republic of Korea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Pyongyang

POPULATION: 23.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 46,540 sq. miles
(120,540 sq. km)

DENSITY: 514 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Korean*, Chinese

RELIGIONS: Government-controlled religions include Chondogyo, Buddhism, and Christianity

ETHNIC MIX: Korean 100%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: N. Korean won = 100 chon